

Synthesize Across Sources

Study Guide - Arguments & Sources

1. Learning goal

Combine information from two or more sources to form a new conclusion that no single source fully provides on its own.

2. What this skill means

Synthesis is not a list of summaries. You use one source together with another to answer a shared question, resolve a tradeoff, or draw a conclusion that depends on both pieces of information.

3. Do not confuse it with

Do not choose an answer supported by only one source when the question asks for combined evidence. Do not invent a compromise that sounds sensible but is not supported.

4. How GED-style questions may ask it

Questions may ask: "Which conclusion is best supported by both sources?", "What can be concluded when the sources are considered together?", "Which plan is best supported by all the evidence?", or "Which statement synthesizes the sources without overstating them?"

5. Repeatable method

- Summarize each source in one line.
- Identify the shared decision or question.
- Mark where the sources support, limit, or extend each other.
- Build a conclusion that requires information from more than one source.
- Check that every part of the conclusion has source support.

6. Worked example

Source 1 shows courtyard temperatures are highest near the west wall after 2 p.m. Source 2 shows a full shade structure is expensive and cannot be

installed this year. Source 3 shows portable shade can be installed quickly but covers less area.

Question: What conclusion is best supported by all three sources?

Reasoning: The heat data identify the urgent location, while the cost and timing data make a phased response more practical than a full immediate build.

Best answer: Use portable shade at the hottest area now while planning a larger permanent solution later.

7. Common traps

- Repeating Source 1 and ignoring Source 2.
- Choosing the most ambitious plan even when timing or cost evidence contradicts it.
- Inventing a conclusion based on outside knowledge rather than the supplied sources.

8. Diagnostic help

- If your answer can be supported without reading one of the sources, it may not be true synthesis.
- If one source gives a limitation, your final conclusion should usually reflect that limitation.
- If your conclusion adds a new fact, identify which source actually supports it.

9. Quick check

Source A says the north entrance has the highest pedestrian count. Source B says only the north entrance has room for a ramp without moving utilities.

What conclusion can be synthesized?

Check yourself: If the goal is to place one ramp where it can serve many users without utility relocation, the north entrance has support from both sources.